STEADFAST MEN

Lesson 21 · Your Daughter Is Watching

Transcript · Wes Hart

Hey. Come on and sit. Good to see you in a chair. Uh, some of you are still wearing the day. You sat down anyway. I'm glad. I rehearsed a gentle hello on the drive over here. I have— I have done that in my own driveway. Walked in full of it. Kind voice. Patient face. First thing I actually said was about the shoes. She looked at the shoes. Uh, then she looked at me. The hello was still out in the truck. Last lesson we stayed with a husband and his wife. What a man keeps, and what he withholds, when the promise is ordinary. Hold that. In this lesson the girl who has been watching the two of you gets the hour. If there is no girl, stay in the chair. I'll get to you. You are in this. Sons in the house and no girl, stay. A man on his own, stay. Uh, this hour still has your name on it. I'm Wes. I go to work, I go home, Uh, and I have a daughter who files things I thought were private. Here's what I want you to hear. She is not waiting on the speech you meant. She is reading the man who arrived. The face. The tone. The way you treat her mother when you are tired and you think nobody's taking notes. Somebody is. Uh, she has been in school on you longer than you have been trying to teach. Before you felt ready. You know, before you had a plan. A lot of what she believes about a man got decided on an ordinary afternoon. You know the one. Boots off. Mind still back at the job. The one where you came through the door already spent. If you already feel behind, Uh, I'm with you on plenty of days. This hour is for telling the truth about what she has been learning, and for putting a truer thing where she can actually see it.

One sentence puts four marks on a real man. I have not improved them. Here they are. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's. You've heard them in this room. We are not— we are not rebuilding the list in this lesson. We're setting them down over a girl who is already watching. Stop waiting. A glad face is a decision you make while you still have one. Pick up the weight. Whatever your face is teaching has your name on it. Go first. Honor her mother out loud, where your daughter can hear it, including the hour it costs you. Work for God's pay. The fun dad gets the photo. The ordinary face gets the Father's eye. That is the reward that lasts. Say them over your own kitchen. A girl can tell a poster from a man, right? I mean the man who actually lives there. Now the claim, plain. Your daughter is watching. If you want to know what kind of man she will marry, look at how you have been treating her mother. That is the man. Uh, she is taking in three things whether you meant to teach or not. What a man is. What a woman should be able to count on. What she herself is worth. Uh, you don't get to shelve it until you feel like a finished father. It is already running. In the kitchen. In the truck. In the tone you use Uh, when somebody asks you for the tape. How many of you are fairly sure your face stays neutral? Go on. Nobody's grading

the hands. Yeah. I had mine up on the inside. Neutral is usually just unexamined. She examined it. And, you know, she was probably right.

Put your ear on this. Deuteronomy six, verse seven. Impress them on your children. Talk about them when you sit at home and when you walk along the road, when you lie down and when you get up. Sit. Walk. Lie down. Get up. That is the school. The ride will do the teaching. The sink will do it. The minute before anybody is impressive will do it. She is collecting you there. First thing she collects. What a man is. You are the early picture. The men who come after get set next to what she saw. Uh, pictures teach before speeches do. If you are steady when you're tired, steady starts to feel like a man. If you vanish into a screen the minute you sit, absence starts to feel like a man. Uh, if you stay gentle on a hard day, a harsh voice will strike her as something that doesn't belong in the house. She will notice. You know, if you go harsh when the day runs long, she may call the harshness normal and go looking for a house that sounds like it. Or she may spend years braced every time a man sighs. Uh, choose the picture on purpose. The four marks, lived where she can see them, become the word in her head. Let me tell on a sigh. My wife asked where the tape was. Simple question. Uh, I produced this long breath, like the tape had personally offended me. An hour later, from the hall, my daughter aimed that same breath at her brother. Same length. Same verdict. I have never been quoted more accurately. Uh, she wasn't mocking the room. She was, you know, taking notes. A man, inconvenienced, sounds like that. I thought— I thought a sigh stayed in the kitchen. It walked down the hall. It became a definition.

Second thing she collects. What a woman should be able to count on. She will not lift that out of a fine talk about respect. She lifts it from the way her mother is treated in the rooms they share with you. Proverbs thirty-one, verse twenty-eight. Her children arise and call her blessed. Her husband also, and he praises her. The praise is supposed to be audible. Uh, thanks she can hear. Her idea, left in her mouth, until she is actually done. Your hand, gentle, where a child sees it and doesn't have to guess. She also writes down the small cut. The quiet you carry until the house steps around you. The man she trusts later will look a lot like those notes. You want a forecast, right? Think about the last hard evening you and her mother were both tired. The tone you actually used. That is the forecast. I learned it turned around in a van, Uh, both kids in the back. I was right about the road. I said so in the tone of a man handing down a verdict. My wife went quiet. At the next light my daughter repeated the correction back to her mother. Word for word. Trying to help. I heard my own voice in a girl's mouth Uh, and I wanted the seat to take me. I have been right about a turn and wrong about a whole minivan. I mean, being right was cheap. What she carried home cost more. She will— she will practice on her mother whatever you practice first. If the house has two addresses, hear this kindly. A true complaint still doesn't belong in your daughter's ear. When you cut her mother down, the girl feels it land on her. She is standing close to both of you. Miles don't move her off that spot.

Third thing. What she is worth. She reads it when you look at her, and when your eyes stay somewhere else. Approval pays for a thing she did. Delight pays for the person she is. Uh, a girl can collect approval and still go to bed hungry, because the hunger was never about the prize. God is clear on the difference. Psalm one forty-nine, verse four. For the Lord takes delight in his people. He crowns the humble with victory. Delight. A gladness that she is His, before she has earned a thing. Yours can be a smaller echo. A true one. Be a gladness she can actually see. On an ordinary walk in the door. You know the look she gives you. Hand that look something true. Uh, if she has to buy your attention with a result, she learns her worth rides with the result. The result slips, and something in her slips with it. Uh, if the gladness shows because she walked into the room, the question was settled before she performed. I got this backward in the garage. My daughter built a birdhouse. Crooked. Full of pride. I went straight to the hinge. I had, uh, opinions. She waited. Then she said, do you like that I made it. I had reviewed a hinge. The hinge was fine. Uh, she was asking about herself. Approval talked about the wood. Delight would have answered her. Look up. Let her see the gladness. If it stays— if it stays private, she has nothing to read, and she is reading anyway. Uh, say her name like you're glad it belongs to somebody alive in the room. Set the thing in your hands down before she finishes the first sentence. That is a man done waiting with his actual face.

Let me tell you about a man. I'll call him Harlan. Uh, I've known him a long time. He keeps the mowers running up and down his street. His girl sang in the back row at church. Uh, not a solo. A robe that ran long. One morning she caught the hem, lost the words, and her mouth kept moving over nothing. She found him. Third row. Hymnal open. He wanted the song to go well for her. His face tightened. She saw it. In the truck she said, you looked like I broke something. He told her she did fine. She said, your mouth did. Your face filed a complaint. He sat with that in the driveway until the cab got warm. He had wanted a standard. She had received a wince. He almost— he almost explained that he was only pulling for her. Uh, she already had the data. After that she stopped telling him about the things she might miss. He heard about them once they were safely over. He asked why. She said, I got tired of watching you watch me miss. That landed. He changed one practice. Before she left the house for anything that could go wrong, he said the glad sentence in the kitchen, with nothing on the line. I'm glad you're my girl. The rest can be whatever it is. He still gets the face wrong when he is tired. Uh, he repairs it faster now. She can tell a repair from a performance. He told me she called after a class that had gone badly. First words were, I'm okay. You don't have to build a funeral. Uh, he laughed when he said it. Then he went quiet. The stretch where she didn't call was the stretch that scared him. She calls again. That is a face she is willing to look for.

The names come next. They are cheaper than we pretend, and she spends them anyway. She grows toward the name you give her. I wrote my daughter a long note once. Left it on the counter. I also— I also called her the messy one a few times that same afternoon, like it was a cute fact about the house. At supper she quoted the nickname. She did not quote the note. Uh,

the nickname won. A line she hears in passing beats a paragraph she has to go find. So ask it straight. What have your words been calling her? Even if the true answer is nothing. Uh, nothing is a name. A blank gets filled by whatever is loud nearby. Give her one particular gladness about who she is. The way she notices the quiet kid. And tell her you love her on a day she didn't win a thing. Somebody will hand her those same words with a hook in them. If she has only heard them when a man wanted something, the hook is harder to see. Uh, words still need minutes under them. A fine sentence in the truck dies if you never sit down. I mean the unhurried minutes. The puzzle on the counter you leave unfinished until she is there. The tailgate, while she talks about people you will never meet, and you stay past the point where you've heard enough. There is also a stretch where her answers get short and her shoulder gets in the way. Some men match the quiet and call it respect. Uh, often it is just relief. Let the short answers be hers. Keep the ride. Keep her chair. Say you're for her, then show it without a speech every time she looks up. On the far side of that stretch she will know who stayed.

She needs a man who is awake. Awake, and kind about it. You know who she is with. You have said why. Uh, you told her, before she needs it, that if a boy gets careless she can call and you will come. The ride back will be a rescue, not a second ordeal she has to survive. You don't hand her off to a young man you have never met. You also— you also don't make a house she has to sneak out of just to feel like a person. And you keep her safe from you. The temper. The line that gets a laugh and leaves a mark. A hard day that picks her as the place it lands. A girl who spends her night managing a man's mood learns a sad job. She may go looking for a life that feels like that job. She may go numb so the job can't find her. Stay with me on the eyes. She is learning what you think a woman is for. The line you stand in. The picture that loads and holds you. The extra second when somebody passes the work. If your eyes go hunting, she files herself in that same drawer. If your eyes come home to her mother, she files a faithful man under possible. Uh, that is a sane hope. Let her hear you pray her name. Her actual name, aimed at God, and then you tell her you did. A girl who has heard that will recognize the shape later. A man on his knees is different from a man who only talks about kneeling. One warning, and I mean this. She can read guilt on a face. Don't carry this room home on your brow and call the weight sincerity. Tell the Father the truth. Tell a brother. Then let her catch you glad she walked into the kitchen. A repaired man is allowed to smile at his girl.

Some of you are past the years when she lived down the hall. Uh, the window did not close when she got her own key. She is still watching. Uh, grown does not mean done. She reads the man who shows up now. Have you changed. Will you show up now in the places you were thin. If she has little ones, they are learning the same man. They will trust what she already suspects. Your blessing does not retire because her address did. If you failed her, Uh, say it in plain words. Leave the defense off the end. A defense is how a man keeps the comfort and hands her the weight. If you have never said you are proud of who she is, the call feels late. Make it. It can close a crack she stopped mentioning. If you failed— if you failed her young, you are not

hunting a time machine. You are telling the truth, then becoming a man she can call. Some of you keep two houses. Uh, you will miss hours. That loss is real. It is not a permit. Don't speak against her mother. Not when your daughter baits you. Not when the complaint is accurate. Not when you are wrung out. Uh, show up for the hours that are yours. Ask cleanly for a few more, without making her the rope between two adults. Uh, call in a rhythm she can count on. Including the stretches where she says she's fine Uh, and the call stays short. The long talk gets purchased by the short ones. Give her a place that stays hers. Her sweatshirt on a hook. A drawer you don't empty when the visit ends. Uh, the split shook the floor under her. A father who shows up, stays clean, and is still growing is ground she can use while it shakes.

Some of you have no daughter. Stay. This hour is yours too. I mean it. A girl in reach is enough. Uh, stay for her sake. How many of you is that? Let me see you. I want you in it. Good. Hold your seat when the page sounds like another man's house. A niece. A girl at church. Your brother's girl. The one waiting in a hall while her mom hunts the keys. She is already reading the men around her. Let one of them be good, and let her see it. I'll call him Curtis. No kids in his house. Uh, he holds a door after the service while families sort coats and kids. A girl who waited on her mom started handing him the extra bulletin, like he belonged to the job. Her mom caught him one day. She said, my girl told me on the way home. You thank the women who fold the programs. She noticed. Curtis looked at me like I'd accused him of a crime he didn't know he had committed. Uh, he said, I didn't know I was teaching. I was trying not to be a fool in a hallway. That was enough. A girl saw a man treat women as if they mattered, where anybody could watch, and she kept it. Uh, do it where you can be seen. Be honorable on purpose. Don't slip off alone with a girl who is not yours. Part of the gift is that a good man can be safe. Honor a mother, or a sister, once, where a girl can watch the honor instead of hearing about it later. And young men, hear this before you get clever. A girlfriend is not a daughter to practice on. Uh, she is not the page. She is a woman. That is a different trust. You can— you can become a man a girl could trust someday without using a woman as the drill.

A room like this is never one kind of man. Let me walk a few chairs. If you are young, and no child lives with you, you are not parked. The face is already being built. Uh, the way you speak about a woman after she leaves is already being learned. Some girl at your church catches the tone, even when the joke felt like it stayed with the men. If you are married and the girl is still under your roof, Uh, she hears the tone louder than the speech. You can nail a prayer at bedtime and undo it by the way you answer her mother from the other room. If she came to you later, through a marriage, the early years you missed are not a pass. You have the years in your hands. She is learning whether those are safe. Some of you learned, as boys, to scan a father's face before you spoke. Uh, I will not make light of that. The ache is real. It does not license you to hand the same scan to a girl who trusts you. You can be the man where that pattern stops. Get a brother next to you while you learn a different face. If she is grown, don't let a polite quiet pretend it is peace. You know, quiet can be distance with good manners on it. And if the work is

going well, you can pay for the whole calendar. The class. The shoes. The trip. You can still miss the minute in the car when she was ready to talk and you were ready to be efficient. A receipt cannot look her in the eye. Uh, I have hidden inside being useful. Useful can feel like care. She needed a man who looked up. One true sentence. One honor she can see. One face you choose before the moment shows up.

Let me set it down where you can carry it. Your daughter is watching. She is learning what a man is, what a woman should be able to count on, and what she is worth. A lot of that school is the sitting and the walking, the lying down and the getting up. The speech can wait. The face cannot. What I hope you take from the chair is a face you can name, one sentence of delight about who she is, and one honor a girl actually sees. Your workbook has this part. In a minute you will sit at the tables Uh, and work it together. Get the questions in your ear. What has your face been teaching, and what have your words been calling her, even if the honest answer is nothing? Say it out loud. Uh, a blank is an answer. Which of the three lessons have you been teaching badly? Name it. Leave the flattering one alone. What are you going to do? One delight sentence about who she is. Honor her mother where she can see it, day by day, while she can hear you. Uh, if she is grown, make the call you keep postponing. Say what you assumed she already owned. If you have no daughter, honor a mother or a sister where a girl can see it. Tell a brother the three lessons and the one you have taught badly. Ask him what his girl is taking from him. If there is no girl, ask what a girl nearby would learn from the way he treats women. Write the line where you will see it. If you want to know what kind of man your daughter will marry, look at how you have been treating her mother. That is the man. Same four marks you've carried all along. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's. Don't leave— don't leave the gladness in the truck. Let her catch you glad. Go on to your tables.